Lesson 50 material: Commonly Confused Words and Spelling

English Stage 3 (C1) · Unit 5: Argument and Academic Style

6.1: Commonly Confused Words

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Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

Learning Objectives

1. Identify commonly confused words.
2. Use strategies to avoid commonly confused words.

Just as a mason uses bricks to build sturdy homes, writers use words to build successful documents. Consider the construction of a building. Builders need to use tough, reliable materials to build a solid and structurally sound skyscraper. From the foundation to the roof and every floor in between, every part is necessary. Writers need to use strong, meaningful words from the first sentence to the last and in every sentence in between.

You already know many words that you use every day as part of your writing and speaking vocabulary. You probably also know that certain words fit better in certain situations. Letters, e-mails, and even quickly jotted grocery lists require the proper selection of vocabulary. Imagine you are writing a grocery list to purchase the ingredients for a recipe but accidentally write down cilantro when the recipe calls for parsley. Even though cilantro and parsley look remarkably alike, each produces a very different effect in food. This seemingly small error could radically alter the flavor of your dish!

Having a solid everyday vocabulary will help you while writing, but learning new words and avoiding common word errors will make a real impression on your readers. Experienced writers know that deliberate, careful word selection and usage can lead to more polished, more meaningful work. This chapter covers word choice and vocabulary-building strategies that will improve your writing.

Recognizing Commonly Confused Words in Your Writing

Some words in English cause trouble for speakers and writers because these words share a similar pronunciation, meaning, or spelling with another word. These words are called commonly confused words. For example, read aloud the following sentences containing the commonly confused words *new* and *knew*:

I liked her *new* sweater.

I *knew* she would wear that sweater today.

These words may sound alike when spoken, but they carry entirely different usages and meanings. *New* is an adjective that describes the sweater, and *knew* is the past tense of the verb *to know*. To read a general word use for adjectives, verbs, and other parts of speech see Chapter 1.

New and *knew* are just two of the words that can be confusing because of their similarities. Familiarize yourself with the following list of commonly confused words. Recognizing these words in your own writing and in other pieces of writing can help you choose the correct word.

Commonly Confused Words

A, An, And

- *A* (article). Used before a word that begins with a consonant.

a key, **a** mouse, **a** screen

- *An* (article). Used before a word that begins with a vowel.

an airplane, **an** ocean, **an** igloo

- *And* (conjunction). Connects two or more words together.

peanut butter **and** jelly, pen **and** pencil, jump **and** shout

Accept, Except

- *Accept* (verb). Means to take or agree to something offered.

They **accepted** our proposal for the conference.

- *Except* (conjunction). Means only or but.

We could fly there **except** the tickets cost too much.

Affect, Effect

- *Affect* (verb). Means to create a change.

Hurricane winds **affect** the amount of rainfall.

- *Effect* (noun). Means an outcome or result.

The heavy rains will have an **effect** on the crop growth.

Are, Our

- *Are* (verb). A conjugated form of the verb *to be*.

My cousins **are** all tall and blonde.

- *Our* (pronoun). Indicates possession, usually follows the pronoun *we*.

We will bring **our** cameras to take pictures.

By, Buy

- *By* (preposition). Means next to.

My glasses are **by** the bed.

- *Buy* (verb). Means to purchase.

I will **buy** new glasses after the doctor's appointment.

Its, It's

- *Its* (pronoun). A form of *it* that shows possession.

The butterfly flapped **its** wings.

- *It's* (contraction). Joins the words *it* and *is*.

It's the most beautiful butterfly I have ever seen.

Know, No

- *Know* (verb). Means to understand or possess knowledge.

I **know** the male peacock sports the brilliant feathers.

- *No*. Used to make a negative.

I have **no** time to visit the zoo this weekend.

Loose, Lose

- *Loose* (adjective). Describes something that is not tight or is detached.

Without a belt, her pants are **loose** on her waist.

- *Lose* (verb). Means to forget, to give up, or to fail to earn something.

She will **lose** even more weight after finishing the marathon training.

Of, Have

- *Of* (preposition). Means *from* or *about*.

I studied maps **of** the city to know where to rent a new apartment.

- *Have* (verb). Means to possess something.

I **have** many friends to help me move.

- *Have* (linking verb). Used to connect verbs.

I should **have** helped her with that heavy box.

Quite, Quiet, Quit

- *Quite* (adverb). Means *really* or *truly*.

My work will require **quite** a lot of concentration.

- *Quiet* (adjective). Means not loud.

I need a **quiet** room to complete the assignments.

- *Quit* (verb). Means to stop or to end.

I will **quit** when I am hungry for dinner.

Right, Write

- *Right* (adjective). Means proper or correct.

When bowling, she practices the **right** form.

- *Right* (adjective). Also means the opposite of left.

The ball curved to the **right** and hit the last pin.

- *Write* (verb). Means to communicate on paper.

After the team members bowl, I will **write** down their scores.

Set, Sit

- *Set* (verb). Means to put an item down.

She **set** the mug on the saucer.

- *Set* (noun). Means a group of similar objects.

All the mugs and saucers belonged in a **set**.

- *Sit* (verb). Means to lower oneself down on a chair or another place

I'll **sit** on the sofa while she brews the tea.

Suppose, Supposed

- *Suppose* (verb). Means to think or to consider

I **suppose** I will bake the bread, because no one else has the recipe.

- *Suppose* (verb). Means to suggest.

Suppose we all split the cost of the dinner.

- *Supposed* (verb). The past tense form of the verb suppose, meaning required or allowed.

She was **supposed** to create the menu.

Than, Then

- *Than* (conjunction). Used to connect two or more items when comparing

Registered nurses require less schooling **than** doctors.

- *Then* (adverb). Means next or at a specific time.

Doctors first complete medical school and **then** obtain a residency.

Their, They're, There

- *Their* (pronoun). A form of *they* that shows possession.

The dog walker feeds **their** dogs everyday at two o'clock.

- **They're** the sweetest dogs in the neighborhood.
- *There* (adverb). Indicates a particular place.

The dogs'bowls are over **there**, next to the pantry.

- *There* (pronoun). Indicates the presence of something

There are more treats if the dogs behave.

To, Two, Too

- *To* (preposition). Indicates movement.

Let's go **to** the circus.

- *To*. A word that completes an infinitive verb.

to play, **to** ride, **to** watch.

- *Two*. The number after one. It describes how many.

Two clowns squirted the elephants with water.

- *Too* (adverb). Means *also* or *very*.

The tents were **too** loud, and we left.

Use, Used

- *Use* (verb). Means to apply for some purpose.

We **use** a weed whacker to trim the hedges.

- He **used** the lawnmower last night before it rained.
- *Used to*. Indicates something done in the past but not in the present

He **used to** hire a team to landscape, but now he landscapes alone.

Who's, Whose

- **Who's** the new student? **Who's** met him?
- *Whose* (pronoun). A form of *who* that shows possession.

Whose schedule allows them to take the new student on a campus tour?

Your, You're

- *Your* (pronoun). A form of *you* that shows possession.

Your book bag is unzipped.

- **You're** the girl with the unzipped book bag.

The English language contains so many words; no one can say for certain how many words exist. In fact, many words in English are borrowed from other languages. Many words have multiple meanings and forms, further expanding the immeasurable number of English words. Although the list of commonly confused words serves as a helpful guide, even these words may have more meanings than shown here. ***When in doubt, consult an expert: the dictionary!***

Exercise :

Complete the following sentences by selecting the correct word.

1. My little cousin turns _____ (to, too, two) years old tomorrow.
2. The next-door neighbor's dog is _____ (quite, quiet, quit) loud. He barks constantly throughout the night.
3. _____ (Your, You're) mother called this morning to talk about the party.

4. I would rather eat a slice of chocolate cake _____ (than, then) eat a chocolate muffin.
5. Before the meeting, he drank a cup of coffee, and _____ (than, then) he brushed his teeth.
6. Do you have any _____ (loose, lose) change to pay the parking meter?
7. Father must _____ (have, of) left his briefcase at the office.
8. Before playing ice hockey, I was _____ (suppose, supposed) to read the contract, but I only skimmed it and signed my name quickly, which may _____ (affect, effect) my understanding of the rules.
9. Tonight she will _____ (set, sit) down and _____(right, write) a cover letter to accompany her résumé and job application.
10. It must be fall, because the leaves _____ (are, our) changing, and _____ (it's, its) getting darker earlier.

Strategies to Avoid Commonly Confused Words

When writing, you need to choose the correct word according to its spelling and meaning in the context. Not only does selecting the correct word improve your vocabulary and your writing, but it also makes a good impression on your readers. It also helps reduce confusion and improve clarity. The following strategies can help you avoid misusing confusing words.

1. **Use a dictionary.** Keep a dictionary at your desk while you write. Look up words when you are uncertain of their meanings or spellings. Many dictionaries are also available online, and the Internet's easy access will not slow you down. Check out your cell phone or smartphone to see if a dictionary app is available.
2. **Keep a list of words you commonly confuse.** Be aware of the words that often confuse you. When you notice a pattern of confusing words, keep a list nearby, and consult the list as you write. Check the list again before you submit an assignment to your instructor.
3. **Study the list of commonly confused words.** You may not yet know which words confuse you, but before you sit down to write, study the words on the list. Prepare your mind for working with words by reviewing the commonly confused words identified in this chapter.

Tip

Commonly confused words appear in many locations, not just at work or at school. Be on the lookout for misused words wherever you find yourself throughout the day. Make a mental note of the error and remember its correction for your own pieces of writing. Also, remember that spellcheck will not usually catch these words because they would be spelled correctly.

Figure: A Commonly Misused Word on a Public Sign

Do you see the mistake? Because this sign was probably created using a computer, you can see that spellcheck would NOT catch this because it is a word – just not the right word!

Writers at Work

All employers value effective communication. From an application to an interview to the first month on the job, employers pay attention to your vocabulary. You do not need a large vocabulary to succeed, but you do need to be able to express yourself clearly and avoid commonly misused words.

When giving an important presentation on the effect of inflation on profit margins, you must know the difference between *effect* and *affect* and choose the correct word. When writing an e-mail to confirm deliveries, you must know if the shipment will arrive in *to* days, *too* days, or *two* days. Confusion may arise if you choose the wrong word.

Consistently using the proper words will improve your communication and make a positive impression on your boss and colleagues.

Exercise :

The following paragraph contains eleven errors. Find each misused word and correct it by adding the proper word.

The original United States Declaration of Independence sets in a case at the Rotunda for the Charters of Freedom as part of the National Archives in Washington, DC. Since 1952, over one million visitors each year of passed through the Rotunda too snap a photograph to capture they're experience. Although signs state, "No Flash Photography," forgetful tourists leave the flash on, an a bright light flickers for just a millisecond. This millisecond of light may not seem like enough to effect the precious document, but supposed how much light could be generated when all those milliseconds are added up. According to the National Archives dministrators, its enough to significantly damage the historic document. So, now, the signs display quit a different message: "No Photography." Visitors continue to travel to see the Declaration that began are country, but know longer can personal pictures serve as mementos. The administrators'compromise, they say, is a visit to the gift shop for a preprinted photograph.

Key Takeaways

- In order to write accurately, it is important for writers to be aware of commonly confused words.
- Although commonly confused words may look alike or sound alike, their meanings are very different.
- Consulting the dictionary is one way to make sure you are using the correct word in your writing. You may also keep a list of commonly confused words nearby when you write or study the chart in this book.
- Choosing the proper words leaves a positive impression on your readers.

6.2: Spelling

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Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

Learning Objectives

1. Identify common spelling rules.
2. Identify commonly misspelled words.
3. Identify commonly misused homonyms.

One essential aspect of good writing is accurate spelling. With computer spell checkers, spelling may seem simple, but these programs fail to catch every error. Spell checkers identify some errors, but writers still have to consider the flagged words and suggested replacements. Writers are still responsible for the errors that remain.

For example, if the spell checker highlights a word that is misspelled and gives you a list of alternative words, you may choose a word that you never intended even though it is spelled correctly. This can change the meaning of your sentence. It can also confuse readers, making them lose interest. Computer spell checkers are useful editing tools, but they can never replace human knowledge of spelling rules, homonyms, and commonly misspelled words.

Common Spelling Rules

The best way to master new words is to understand the key spelling rules. Keep in mind, however, that some spelling rules carry exceptions. A spell checker may catch these exceptions, but knowing them yourself will prepare you to spell accurately on the first try. You may want to try memorizing each rule and its exception like you would memorize a rhyme or lyrics to a song.

Write *i* before *e* except after *c*, or when pronounced *ay* like “neighbor” or “weigh.”

- achieve, niece, alien
- receive, deceive

When words end in a consonant plus *y*, drop the *y* and add an *i* before adding another ending.

- happy + er = happier
- cry + ed = cried

When words end in a vowel plus *y*, keep the *y* and add the ending.

- delay + ed = delayed

Memorize the following exceptions to this rule: *day*, *lay*, *say*, *pay* =*daily*, *laid*, *said*, *paid*

When adding an ending that begins with a vowel, such as *-able*, *-ence*, *-ing*, or *-ity*, drop the last *e* in a word.

- write + ing = writing
- pure + ity = purity

When adding an ending that begins with a consonant, such as *-less*, *-ment*, or *-ly*, keep the last *e* in a word.

- hope + less = hopeless
- advertise + ment = advertisement

For many words ending in a consonant and an *o*, add *-s* when using the plural form.

- photo + s = photos
- soprano + s = sopranos

Add *-es* to words that end in *s*, *ch*, *sh*, and *x*.

- church + es = churches
- fax + es = faxes

Exercise :

Identify and correct the nine misspelled words in the following paragraph.

Sherman J. Alexie Jr. was born in October 1966. He is a Spokane/Coeur d'Alene Indian and an American writer, poet, and filmmaker. Alexie was born with hydrocephalus, or water on the brain. This condition led doctors to predict that he would likly suffer long-term brain damage and possibly mental retardation. Although Alexie survived with no mental disabilitys, he did suffer other serious side effects from his condition that plagud him throughout his childhood. Amazingly, Alexie learned to read by the age of three, and by age five he had read novels such as John Steinbeck's *The Grapes of Wrath*. Raised on an Indian reservation, Alexie often felt aleinated from his peers due to his avid love for reading and also from the long-term effects of his illness, which often kept him from socializeing with his peers on the reservation. The reading skills he displaid at such a young age foreshadowed what he would later become. Today Alexie is a prolific and successful writer with several story anthologeis to his credit, noteably *The Lone Ranger and Tonto Fistfight in Heaven* and *The Toughest Indian in the World*. Most of his fiction is about contemporary Native Americans who are influenced by pop culture and pow wows and everything in between. His work is sometimes funny but always thoughtful and full of richness and depth. Alexie also writes poetry, novels, and screenplays. His latest collection of storys is called *War Dances*, which came out in 2009.

Commonly Misspelled Words

Below is a list of commonly misspelled words. You probably use these words every day in either speaking or writing. Each word has a segment in bold type, which indicates the problem area of the word that is often spelled incorrectly. If you can, use this list as a guide before, during, and after you write.

Table : Commonly Misspelled Words

a**c**ross	dis**app**oint	in**teg**ration	partic**u**lar	sep**ara**te
a**ddr**ess	disa**pp**rove	in**tell**igent	**per**form	sim**ilar**

ans**w**er	do**es**n't	int**ere**st	**per**haps	**sin**ce
arg**u**ment	eig**hth**	int**er**fere	perso**nn**el	sp**ee**ch
a**thl**ete	emba**rr**ass	jew**el**ry	po**sse**ss	stren**gth**
begi**nn**ing	envir**on**ment	jud**gm**ent	po**ss**ible	su**cc**ess
beha**vi**or	exa**gg**erate	knowle**d**ge	**pre**fer	**sur**prise
cal**e**nd**a**r	fam**ili**ar	maint**ain**	pre**jud**ice	**tau**ght
ca**ree**r	fina**lly**	math**e**matics	privil**ege**	temper**a**ture
cons**cie**nce	gove**rn**ment	me**a**nt	pro**bab**ly	th**orou**gh
crow**ded**	gramm**a**r	ne**ce**ssary	**psy**cholo**gy**	though**t**
def**ini**te	hei**gh**t	nerv**ous**	p**ur**sue	tire**d**
d**es**cribe	**ill**egal	o**cc**asion	ref**er**ence	unt**il**
desp**er**ate	immed**iate**ly	opin**ion**	**rhy**th**m**	weig**ht**
di**ffe**rent	import**ant**	opt**i**mist	ridic**ul**ous	wri**tt**en

Tip

Use the following two tricks to help you master these troublesome words:

1. Copy each word a few times and underline the problem area.
2. Copy the words onto flash cards and have a friend test you.

Exercise :

Identify and correct the ten commonly misspelled words in the following paragraphs.

Brooklyn is one of the five boroughs that make up New York City. It is located on the eastern shore of Long Island directly accross the East River from the island of Manhattan. Its beginings stretch back to the sixteenth century when it was founded by the Dutch who originally called it "Breuckelen." Immedietely after the Dutch settled Brooklyn, it came under British rule. However, neither the Dutch nor the British were Brooklyn's first inhabitants. When European settlers first arrived, Brooklyn was largely inhabited by the Lenapi, a collective name for several organized bands of Native American people who settled a large area of land that extended from upstate New York through the entire state of New Jersey. They are sometimes referred to as the Delaware Indians. Over time, the Lenapi succumbed to European diseases or conflicts between European settlers or other Native American enemies. Finalley, they were pushed out of Brooklyn completely by the British.

In 1776, Brooklyn was the site of the first importent battle of the American Revolution known as the Battle of Brooklyn. The colonists lost this battle, which was led by George Washington, but over the next two years they would win the war, kicking the British out of the colonies once and for all.

By the end of the nineteenth century, Brooklyn grew to be a city in its own right. The completion of the Brooklyn Bridge was an ocasion for celebration; transportation and commerce between Brooklyn and Manhattan now became much easier. Eventually, in 1898, Brooklyn lost its seperate identity as an

independent city and became one of five boroughs of New York City. However, in some people's opinien, the intagration into New York City should have never happened; they though Brooklyn should have remained an independent city.

Tip

Eight Tips to Improve Spelling Skills

1. **Read the words in your assignment carefully, and avoid skimming over the page.** Focusing on your written assignment word by word will help you pay close attention to each word's spelling. Skimming quickly, you may overlook misspelled words.
2. **Use mnemonic devices to remember the correct spelling of words.** Mnemonic devices, or memory techniques and learning aids, include inventive sayings or practices that help you remember. For example, the saying "It is important to be a beautiful person inside and out" may help you remember that *beautiful* begins with "be a." The practice of pronouncing the word *Wednesday* Wed-nes-day may help you remember how to spell the word correctly.
3. **Use a dictionary.** Many professional writers rely on the dictionary — either in print or online. If you find it difficult to use a regular dictionary, ask your instructor to help you find a "poor speller's dictionary."
4. **Use your computer's spell checker.** The spell checker will not solve all your spelling problems, but it is a useful tool. See the introduction to this section for cautions about spell checkers.
5. **Keep a list of frequently misspelled words.** You will often misspell the same words again and again, but do not let this discourage you. All writers struggle with the spellings of certain words; they become aware of their spelling weaknesses and work to improve. Be aware of which words you commonly misspell, and you can add them to a list to learn to spell them correctly.
6. **Look over corrected papers for misspelled words.** Add these words to your list and practice writing each word four to five times each. Writing teachers will especially notice which words you frequently misspell, and it will help you excel in your classes if they see your spelling improve.
7. **Test yourself with flashcards.** Sometimes the old-fashioned methods are best, and for spelling, this tried and true technique has worked for many students. You can work with a peer or alone.
8. **Review the common spelling rules explained in this chapter.** Take the necessary time to master the material; you may return to the rules in this chapter again and again, as needed.

Also, remember to focus on spelling during the editing and revising step of the writing process. Start with the big ideas such as organizing your piece of writing and developing effective paragraphs, and then work your way down toward the smaller — but equally important — details like spelling and punctuation. To read more about the writing process and editing and revising, see Chapter 5.

In today's job market, writing e-mails has become a means by which many people find employment. E-mails to prospective employers require thoughtful word choice, accurate spelling, and perfect punctuation. Employers' inboxes are inundated with countless e-mails daily. If even the subject line of an e-mail contains a spelling error, it will likely be overlooked and someone else's e-mail will take priority.

The best thing to do after you proofread an e-mail to an employer and run the spell checker is to have an additional set of eyes go over it with you; one of your teachers may be able to read the e-mail and

give you suggestions for improvement. Most colleges and universities have writing centers, which may also be able to assist you.

Homonyms

Homonyms are words that sound like one another but have different meanings.

Commonly Misused Homonyms

Principle, Principal

- **Principle (noun).** A fundamental concept that is accepted as true.

The **principle** of human equality is an important foundation for all nations.

- **Principal (noun).** The original amount of debt on which interest is calculated.

The payment plan allows me to pay back only the **principal** amount, not any compounded interest.

- **Principal (noun).** A person who is the main authority of a school.

The **principal** held a conference for both parents and teachers.

Where, Wear, Ware

- **Where (adverb).** The place in which something happens.

Where is the restaurant?

- **Wear (verb).** To carry or have on the body.

I will **wear** my hiking shoes when go on a climb tomorrow morning.

- **Ware (noun).** Articles of merchandise or manufacture (usually, *wares*).

When I return from shopping, I will show you my **wares**.

Lead, Led

- **Lead (noun).** A type of metal used in pipes and batteries.

The **lead** pipes in my homes are old and need to be replaced.

- **Led (verb).** The past tense of the verb *lead*.

After the garden, she **led** the patrons through the museum.

Which, Witch

- **Which (pronoun).** Replaces one out of a group.

Which apartment is yours?

- **Witch (noun).** A person who practices sorcery or who has supernatural powers.

She thinks she is a **witch**, but she does not seem to have any powers.

Peace, Piece

- **Peace (noun).** A state of tranquility or quiet.

For once, there was **peace** between the argumentative brothers.

- **Piece (noun).** A part of a whole.

I would like a large **piece** of cake, thank you.

Passed, Past

- **Passed (verb).** To go away or move.

He **passed** the slower cars on the road using the left lane.

- **Past (noun).** Having existed or taken place in a period before the present.

The argument happened in the **past**, so there is no use in dwelling on it.

Lessen, Lesson

- **Lessen (verb).** To reduce in number, size, or degree.

My dentist gave me medicine to **lessen** the pain of my aching tooth.

- **Lesson (noun).** A reading or exercise to be studied by a student.

Today's **lesson** was about mortgage interest rates.

Patience, Patients

- **Patience (noun).** The capacity of being patient (waiting for a period of time or enduring pains and trials calmly).

The novice teacher's **patience** with the unruly class was astounding.

- **Patients (plural noun).** Individuals under medical care.

The **patients** were tired of eating the hospital food, and they could not wait for a home-cooked meal.

Sees, Seas, Seize

- **Sees (verb).** To perceive with the eye.

He **sees** a whale through his binoculars.

- **Seas (plural noun).** The plural of sea, a great body of salt water.

The tidal fluctuation of the oceans and **seas** are influenced by the moon.

- **Seize (verb).** To possess or take by force.

The king plans to **seize** all the peasants' land.

Threw, Through

- **Threw (verb).** The past tense of *throw*.

She **threw** the football with perfect form.

- **Through (preposition).** A word that indicates movement.

She walked **through** the door and out of his life.

Exercise :

Complete the following sentences by selecting the correct homonym.

1. Do you agree with the underlying _____(principle, principal) that ensures copyrights are protected in the digital age?
2. I like to _____(where, wear, ware) unique clothing from thrift stores that do not have company logos on them.
3. Marjan felt like she was being _____(led, lead) on a wild goose chase, and she did not like it one bit.
4. Serina described _____(witch, which) house was hers, but now that I am here, they all look the same.
5. Seeing his friend without a lunch, Miguel gave her a _____(peace, piece) of his apple.
6. Do you think that it is healthy for mother to talk about the _____(passed, past) all the time?
7. Eating healthier foods will _____(lessen, lesson) the risk of heart disease.
8. I know it sounds cliché, but my father had the _____(patients, patience) of a saint.
9. Daniela _____(sees, seas, seize) possibilities in the bleakest situations, and that it is why she is successful.
10. Everyone goes _____(through, threw) hardships in life regardless of who they are.

Key Takeaways

- Accurate, error-free spelling enhances your credibility with the reader.
- Mastering the rules of spelling may help you become a better speller.
- Knowing the commonly misused homonyms may prevent spelling errors.
- Studying the list of commonly misspelled words in this chapter, or studying a list of your own, is one way to improve your spelling skills.